

Three Proofs.

Pablo Picasso, Gertrude Stein, 1905-6

When she was herself, finished, she said It doesn't look like me. Picasso said, It will. Perhaps it will look like her because it is the document and will remain, while she is just a person who will fade. Now, when we think of her, we think of this painting. Picasso was planning ahead. The painting is evidence but not proof. There's no proof that she looked like that, even though we have the document. She existed enough to be painted. She could have been an idea, but that's another kind of existing. The hand is a tool. The brush is a tool. The paint as well. There is no machine here, though the work gets done. The hammer is a tool when banging its head but a lever when pulling up nails. A lever is a machine, has a fulcrum which can be moved to change the ratio of something or other, effort for distance. There is a fulcrum in the mind that can be moved as well. I do not know what else to say about this.

Raphael, Saint George and the Dragon, 1504-6

It's hard to talk about what you believe while you are believing it. Fervor reduces thought to shorthand and all we get is an icon. Give a man a weapon and you have a warrior. Put him on a horse and you have a hero. The weapon is a tool. The horse is a metaphor. Raphael painted this twice--white horse facing east against the greens, white horse facing west against the yellows. The maiden flees or prays, depending. A basic dragon, the kind you'd expect from the Renaissance. Evidence of evil but not proof. There's a companion piece as well: Saint Michael. Paint angels, it's easier: you don't need the horse. Michael stands on Satan's throat, vanquishing, while everything brown burns red. All these things happened. Allegedly. When you paint an evil thing, do you invoke it or take away its power? This has nothing to do with faith but is still a good question. Raphael was trying to say something about spirituality. This could be the definition of painting. The best part of spirituality is reverence. There are other parts. Some people like to hear the sound of their own voice. If you don't believe in the world it would be stupid to paint it. If you don't believe in God, then who are you talking to?

Caravaggio, David with the Head of Goliath, 1609-10

Wanted for murder, a price on his head, Caravaggio does what he always does--he tries to paint his way out of it. This bad boy--whose moodiness came to be called the Baroque, this thug whose soul was as big as Rome and full of anvils---paints his own face on Goliath's severed head and offers himself up as a villain, captured, to escape the hammers of the law. Allegory, yes. A truth as well. But truth doesn't count in law, only proof. He took the gods and made them human. His Bacchus was a worn-out drunk. An animal likely to sleep in a pool of its own sick. He rained the status of the still life, made subjects out of objects, turned nature into drama--the bloom on the grapes, the bloom on the boys, leaves as important as nudes. Exaggerated light, pure theater. Evidence of a mind he delights in. Evicted from Rome, he wants back in. They want his head and he's prepared to give it to them. He paint David in yellow pants while the pope's nephew arranges his pardon. July 1610--

Caravaggio rolls up his paintings and sets sail from Naples, heading north. The stop for supplies. No one's heard of the pardon. Jail. He pays his way out, but the boat and his painting have sailed on without him. He follows. Malaria. He dies three days before his pardon arrives and three days after Rembrandt's fourth birthday. His painted head arrives in Rome weeks later. All painting is sent downstream, into the future.